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Scars



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"SCARS," the nickname stuck in High School. Ingenious, huh? I mean they could have used anything: "Scarletta", "Freddy", "Scarsky and Hutch," but they chose to go with "Scars." At first I despised the name and avoided all of humanity as a result of it, but there was no escape. The ridicule wouldn't have been so bad, in fact it would have never happened, if our PE teacher Ms. Gaisen hadn't made me shower. I hid my scars well throughout the day but when Ms. "Gay"sen forces you to shower in front of everyone there really isn't much to hide.

I decided if I wore nothing but black, spiked my hair all crazy like, and wore a bunch of chains I wouldn't have to avoid them, rather **they** would avoid me. My plan worked for a while but I could still hear *scars* whispered in the hall. In time, I not only got used to the name but as it continued; I started to become proud of it. In a way, it made me who I am today.

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I don't know why I cut myself; maybe for the attention, most likely because it allowed me to escape from my reality, but the fact is it let me feel. Every time I touch them I remember; the scars represent who I am; each tells its own story. The first cut was here, across my bicep; I didn't even mean to do it at first. I was a freshman working on an art project; art, my first love as a child. While others played outside, I would sneak into my closet with my coffee-can filled with broken crayons and draw. My teachers all said I had real talent. The assignment was to cut pictures from magazines to represent who I was? As I was cutting out a picture of a bleeding heart I heard my mom yelling at Carl about not being able to make a car payment. They were still technically "honeymooners" since they had only been married two weeks, but they fought like alcoholics over the last beer. I listened as the two traded verbal blows for roughly ten minutes when, "slap," I heard it echo through the house.

At first I didn't catch on to what the noise even was, but then I heard crying and more slapping, and only Carl yelling. Seeing was just something I needed to do in order to believe, but when I opened my bedroom door I was still in disbelief. My mom was rolled up on the floor like a roly-poly escaping the ignorant hands of a three year old; she was helpless, and so was I. He just kept beating her and beating her and I didn't know what to do. I was afraid that if I ran out to stop him that I would be balled up on the floor also. Standing there I thought I needed to run out and break it up; do something, but then Carl made my decision for me, he threw a lamp in my direction and told me to "Close the

door and mind your own business." As I meagerly shut the door I couldn't help but think that my mom was my business, but fear made sure the door was shut tight.

I remember sitting on my bed not blinking while I continued to cut out the heart for my art project; suddenly school didn't seem all that important. I wanted to do something but couldn't; I wanted control but didn't know how to get it and that's when it happened. I don't even know how but the dull blade of the scissors found its way to my bicep and pressed hard. I couldn't even feel it at first so I kept pressing as hard as I could. When the blood finally trickled off my elbow onto the lily-printed sheets, I felt a sense of pressure released. I don't know how to explain it other than it just felt right; it gave me power; for once I was in control.

You're probably thinking this girl is strange, "cut yourself to gain control." You're right it is strange but it's true. Mutilation was a way of preservation. Feeling the pain of the blade meant being alive; it was actually exhilarating and for a moment the reality that was my mother lying in a heap on the living room floor disappeared. Relief for me came in the shape of a pair of scissors.

Cutting became like what I imagine a fix to be like for a heroine addict; it seemed like I couldn't get through a day without it. Whenever my mom and Carl would fight I found my scissors and a new place on my body to inflict control. I had to move from cutting my arms to cutting my breasts when my mother asked why I was wearing long sleeves in the summer but I didn't care about where the cut would go as long as it got there. I can't even look at my breasts now without thinking about why those scars are there.

The night after my sixteenth birthday I remember the door slowly opening as if death was creeping in. My head was underneath the covers but I knew evil was standing over me; I was right.

"Wake up"

I didn't want to move; I wanted to keep my eyes close and imagine the feelings in my body where part of some bad dream.

"Birthday girl needs to become a woman."

I could feel his hands slide under the covers like a snake seeking its prey as it reached to pull down my pajamas. His face was above mine now; my eyes closed tighter but I knew it was there, I could feel his warm alcohol infested breath on my face.

"Come on baby, you know you want it; moan for me."

I didn't make a sound, even when I could feel him enter me, I didn't make a sound. I searched for a thought anything to help me fight back, but the only thing I could imagine was cutting; of all the things that should go through your mind in a moment like this I imagined slicing my silky skin.

In minutes he was gone and I was left alone in my room to question whether I was caught in a dream or dead. Finding the scissors in my closet and cutting my breasts until I was completely covered in blood let me know that somehow I was still alive.

Before I was a senior in high school Carl raped me seventy six times; I know this because I cut tallies on my chest like a prisoner marks off his remaining days. When you're young and don't know any better you don't look for a way to stop this horrible thing; you just look for a way to cope with it. I knew what Carl was doing was wrong but I didn't know that it shouldn't have happened. Cutting made it go away and that was enough to keep me alive.

In the late afternoon after my high school graduation, I stood in front of the mirror in my empty bedroom and counted; one hundred and fifty seven scars riddled my body from my arms to my feet. Each one brought back a memory; each one made me feel alive.

I couldn't help but think how hideous I looked; how no one in their right mind would ever love me and in that moment is when I wanted to stop cutting myself and cut the one person that brought the most torment to my life: Carl. I picked up the scissors and made my way down the narrow hall to the sound of Carl snoring. He had missed my graduation on account that he was still hung over from the night before. As I started to lift the scissors above my head, they felt heavy. I closed my eyes and visualized myself bringing them down hard, penetrating **him;** again, one, and again, two and again, three; counting again and again seventy-six times. I smiled. I knew that I had to kill; I couldn't just wound him. Rage flooded my head and that's when it happened: Fate.

Before I could open the door to view my potential victim the phone rang and as if a hypnotist snapped his fingers, the scissors dropped to the floor. Carl's snoring came to an abrupt halt, as did my plan to end his life. I knew that if he caught me standing outside his door the punishment would be great, so I scrambled down the hall and answered the phone.

"Hello"

"This is Mike Leavy from the Manhattan Institute of Fine Arts; I need to speak with Sara."

"That's me."

"Sara, I have some great news, we've looked over your portfolio and I can tell you we are quite impressed."

"Does that mean…does it mean…"

"That's what it means Sara; And we also want to offer you a scholarship if you are willing to start with us in our early entrance program set aside for our more talented students; would you be interested in beginning with us next week?"

Fate, a phone call in the mist of my confusion and revenge offered a different type of escape, one that didn't involve me hurting myself, or others. An escape found in the form of success, and **that** door, not Carl's, was the one I decided to step through. That was ten years ago, and I never again had the urge to cut myself. It was as if I had crossed the finish line of some gruesome race. Ten years. And tonight I stand before the mirror again; readying myself for my reunion…and I'm not looking at S*cars* but at Sara, Sara the devoted wife whose husband accepted her based on who she was on the inside, Sara the mother who hangs her daughter's colored pictures on the refrigerator, Sara the artist who earns a living doing something she has loved since childhood. Sara, will walk back into that same building where the whispers began, marked only with success.

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